
**Unit 1, Option E/F,
Topic E/F2: The
Unification of
Germany, 1848-90**

The main focus of this topic is on the nature and extent of Bismarck's responsibility for the unification of Germany and on the ways in which he shaped and influenced its political culture and development to 1890. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on the role of Bismarck as an individual would require some consideration of underlying support for unification (bullet 1), the relative economic and military strength of Austria and Prussia (bullet 2), and the policies and actions of Bismarck (bullet 3). Collectively, the bullet points offer a framework for understanding how ideas and forces combined to produce a united Germany in the period.

The first bullet point focuses on the 1848 revolutions and relates to revolutionary activities within Germany, to the Frankfurt Assembly and its failure, and to constitutional developments in 1849–50 and to the Erfurt Union. Questions will not be set on the causes of the 1848 revolutions but students should have an understanding of the forces which supported and opposed greater unification at that time, knowledge of the reasons for their failure in Germany and their political legacy. They should understand the impact of these events on both liberal and nationalist attitudes and on the relationship between Austria and Prussia.

The second bullet point relates to economic developments both before and after 1848, particularly the establishment of the Zollverein, urban and industrial development, and to the reasons for, and extent of, the economic domination of Prussia within the Confederation. Students should be aware of the implications of industrial growth for military strength, and of the ways in which economic ties and dependency encouraged the development of political links. They should also understand the increasing imbalance of resources between the industrial north and west, and the agricultural south and east, and hence between Prussia and Austria.

The third bullet point relates to the role of Bismarck and the methods by which he pursued unification under Prussian control to 1871. The reference to diplomacy and war relates only to the implications of Prussian foreign policy for the movement towards unification. Students could refer to: Prussian opposition to proposals for reforming the Confederation (1863); the implications of Polish rebellion and the Schleswig-Holstein question for moves towards unification; the Danish (1864) and Austrian (1866) wars; and the establishment of the North German Confederation in 1867. They should have knowledge of the immediate consequences of the Franco-Prussian war for German unification. Questions will not be set which focus directly and exclusively on the military aspects of wars in the 1860s.